LANTERN EDUCATION PARTNERS — SOLUTION PROPOSAL

# Every Day Counts

## A two-year plan to reduce chronic absenteeism at Riverbend Unified, 2026-27 and 2027-28

Prepared for the Board of Education, September 2026

> Illustrative example. Lantern Education Partners and Riverbend Unified are fictional; every price, headcount, date and projected effect here is illustrative.

**The problem evidence is real and sourced on the page.**



THE SITUATION

Contains illustrative figures

# Chronically absent without ever being truant

Chronic absenteeism is a count of missed days for any reason — which is why it can be managed like any other operating metric.

**18** days

10% of a 180-day school year

0.10 × 180 = 18

HOW IT IS COUNTED

Missing **10 percent or more** of school days for any reason — excused, unexcused, or suspension.

Framework for Action: Addressing Chronic Absenteeism through ESSA (ERIC ED617466, 2017)

The federal report-card measure counts 15 days or more; ESSA requires the rate on report cards.

- Excused — illness, appointments
- Unexcused — no accepted reason
- Days out on suspension

## All three count the same way

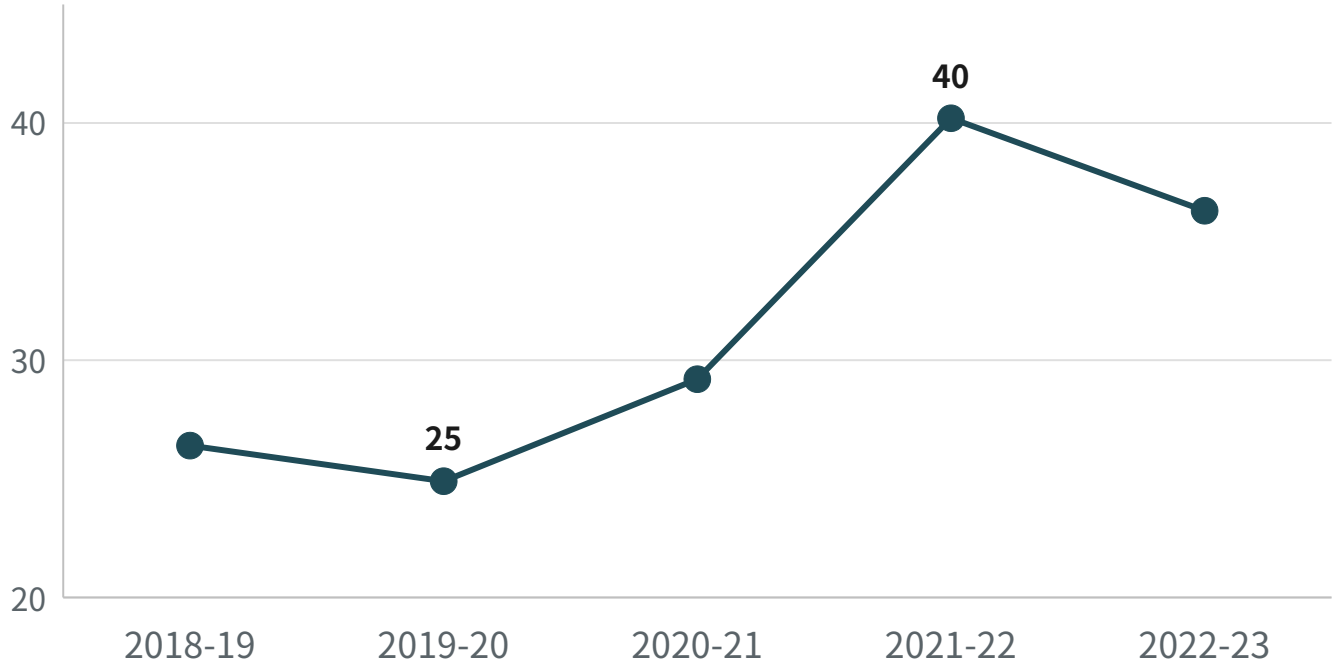
Riverbend's own baseline for 2025-26 is **31%** — about 3,100 of 10,000 students. That is the number this proposal moves.

Illustrative district figures

THE EVIDENCE — PUBLISHED BENCHMARK

# The rate is still ten points above 2018-19

It rose by **half** in the pandemic years and has recovered **less than half** of that.




## HOW THIS WAS COMPUTED

A student-weighted city-wide rate: chronically absent students divided by students contributing 10 or more total days, summed across every All Grades school row in that year.

⚠

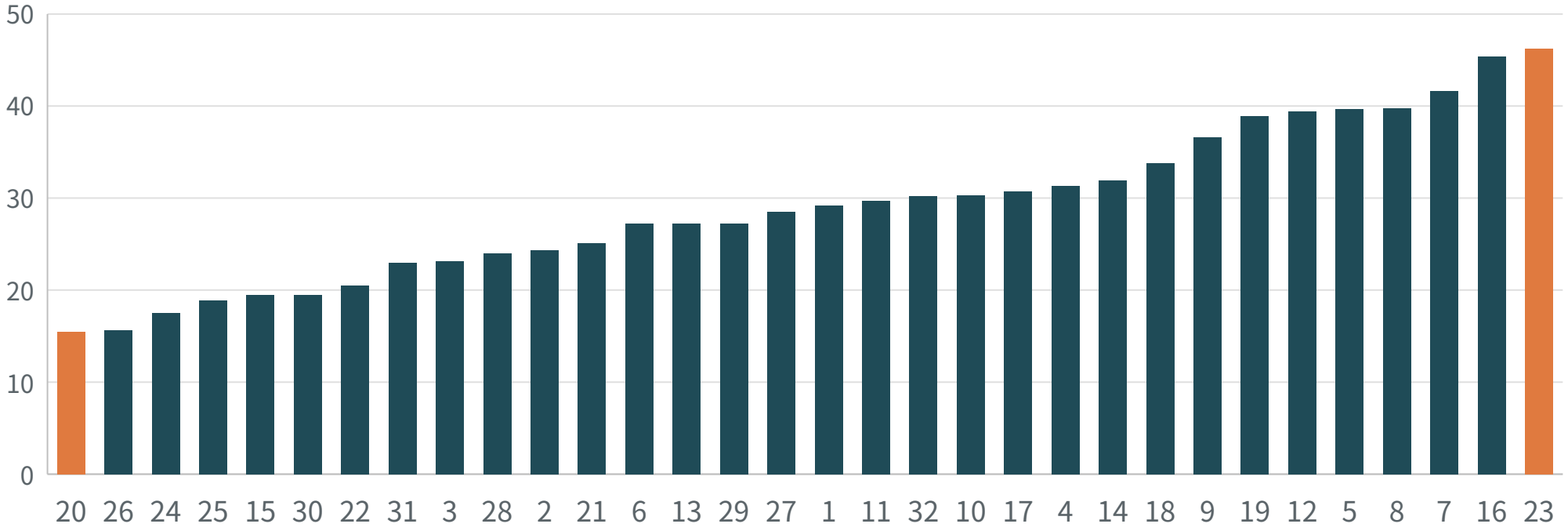
New York City is a published benchmark, not Riverbend's figures.

Source: NYC Open Data — End-of-Year Attendance and Chronic Absenteeism (dataset sgsi-66kk), school years 2018-19 to 2022-23; computed by Lantern.

THE EVIDENCE — DISTRIBUTION

# One city, one year: 16% to 46% across districts

Chronic absenteeism **concentrates**, so a district average is an accounting figure — the plan has to be aimed at the tail.



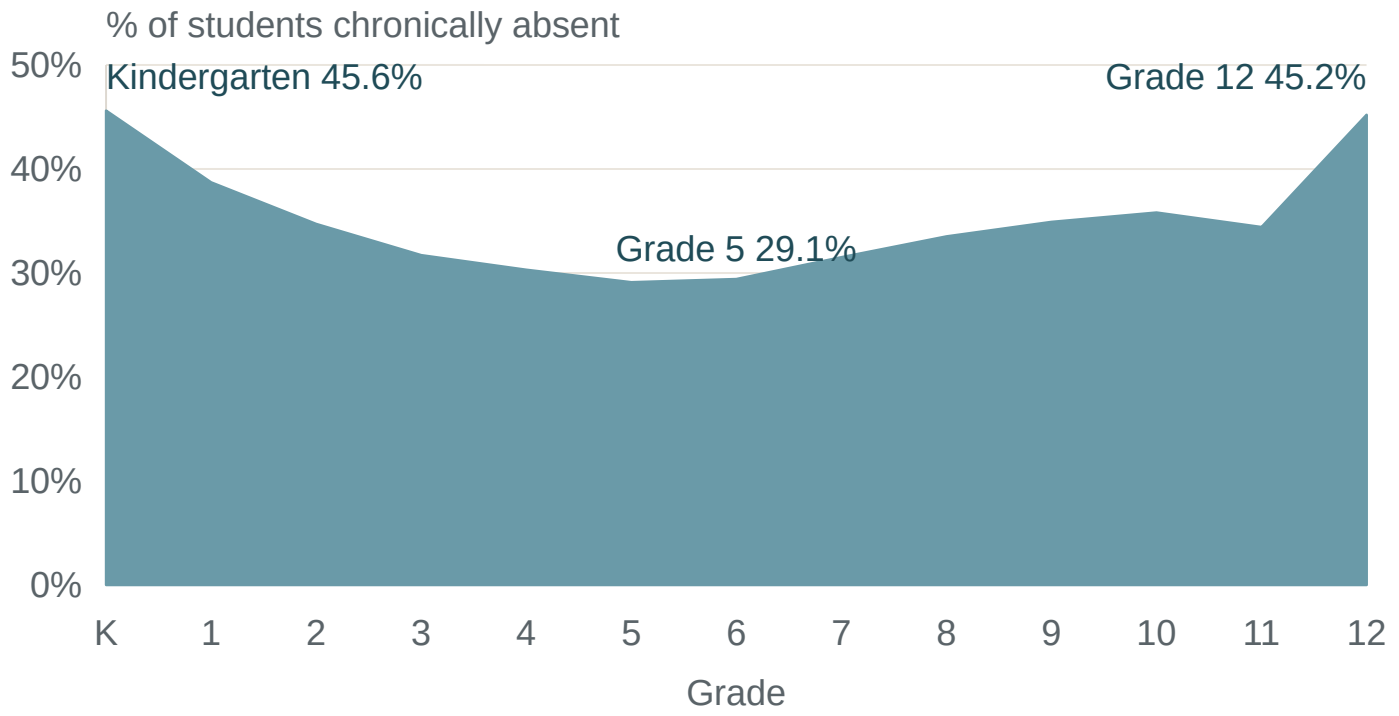

The 32 geographic community school districts, All Grades / All Students, 2018-19, as published. District 75, the citywide special-education district, is excluded at 51.5% because its population is not comparable to a geographic district.

Source: NYC Open Data — End-of-Year Attendance and Chronic Absenteeism by District (dataset hags-jh3e).

THE EVIDENCE — WHERE IT CONCENTRATES

# Two peaks, and one of them is five-year-olds

Absence is worst at the **entry** to school and at the **exit** from it.




## WHY BOTH ENDS MATTER

Students chronically absent in both kindergarten and first grade are much less likely to read at grade level by third grade.

Students not reading at grade level by third grade are four times more likely to drop out of high school.

By sixth grade chronic absenteeism is a leading dropout indicator; by high school attendance predicts dropout better than test scores.

Chart source: NYC Open Data — End-of-Year Attendance and Chronic Absenteeism (sgsi-66kk), 2022-23; student-weighted rate per grade, computed by Lantern. Consequence evidence: Framework for Action: Addressing Chronic Absenteeism through ESSA Implementation (ERIC ED617466, 2017).

WHY STUDENTS MISS SCHOOL

# Four kinds of reasons, and only one is refusal

Researchers group the causes as barriers, aversions, disengagement, and myths.

### Barriers

Unmanaged asthma, diabetes, mental health and vision problems; transport and housing instability.

### Aversions

Bullying, undiagnosed disabilities, and overly punitive discipline.

### Disengagement

A negative school climate, or no supportive relationship at school.

### Myths

Fears such as lice, and the belief that an excused absence does not count.



Illustration, not a photograph of any school

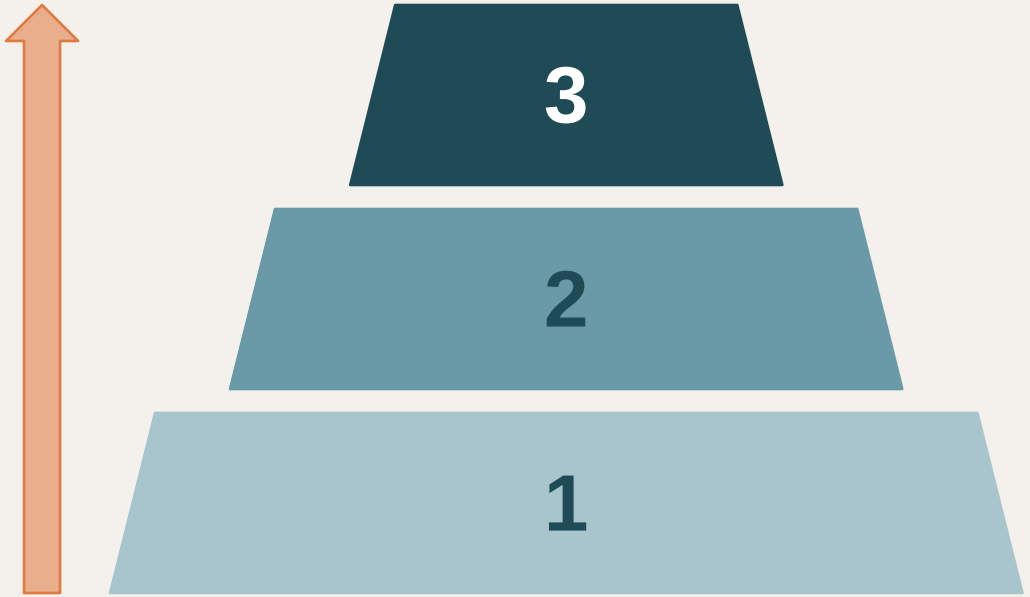
**Three of the four** are conditions a district can change.
The EPA estimates 10.5 million school days are lost to asthma each year.

Source: Framework for Action: Addressing Chronic Absenteeism through ESSA (ERIC ED617466, 2017); EPA asthma figure cited there.

OUR RECOMMENDATION

# Build one attendance system with three tiers

Prevention for everyone, early intervention for the students slipping, and coordinated case support for the students already in crisis.




Rising intensity, fewer students

**Tier 3 — Intensive support**
Students already chronically absent

**Tier 2 — Early intervention**
Students approaching the 10% line

**Tier 1 — Universal prevention**
All students, every day

Lantern designs the system and trains the site leads; **Riverbend runs it.**

Illustrative staffing: one attendance lead per site, one district coordinator.

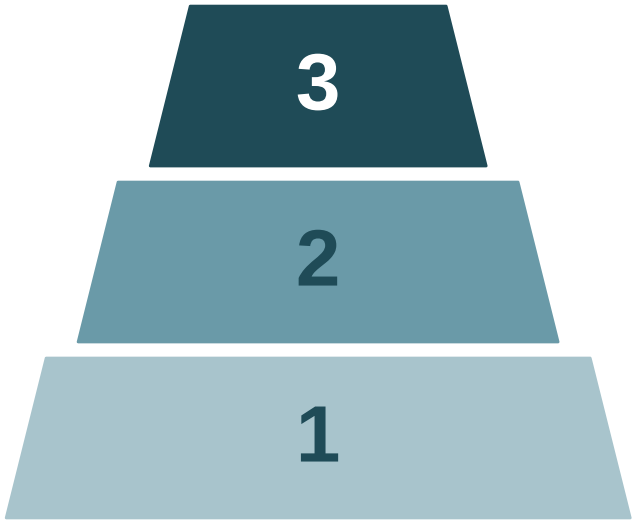
The multi-tiered system of supports comes from Framework for Action (ERIC ED617466, 2017).

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Contains illustrative figures

# Every tier has a trigger, an owner, and a limit

The system escalates on **data**, not on frustration.




**Trigger** — already chronically absent, or referred by the attendance team
**Action** — case review, home visit, community partner referral, family attendance plan
**Owner** — district attendance coordinator

**Trigger** — passes the early-warning threshold in a rolling window
**Action** — same-week family contact, a named adult, a barrier check on health/transport
**Owner** — site attendance lead

**Trigger** — enrolled
**Action** — attendance expectations, positive messaging, daily data for every teacher
**Owner** — site principal

⚠ The boundary: legal action is used only as a **very last resort**.

England's statutory guidance takes the same shape: schools and local authorities support first, and legal interventions apply only where attendance support does not work, is not engaged with, or is not appropriate.

Sources: Framework for Action (ERIC ED617466, 2017); Department for Education, Working together to improve school attendance, first published 6 May 2022.

DELIVERY PLAN — YEAR ONE

Illustrative dates and scope

# Year one ends with a system Riverbend runs itself

Four phases in ten months, each ending in something the board can inspect.

## Phase 1
Sep-Nov 2026

### Baseline and root cause

Attendance data audit, barrier survey, site interviews.

DELIVERABLE

Baseline report with a root-cause profile for each site.

## Phase 2
Dec 2026-Feb 2027

### Design and build

Early-warning thresholds, the teacher dashboard spec, the family contact playbook.

DELIVERABLE

The attendance operating manual.

## Phase 3
Mar-May 2027

### Pilot at three schools

Tier 1 and Tier 2 live, with weekly case review.

DELIVERABLE

Pilot results measured against the baseline.

## Phase 4
Jun-Aug 2027

### Rollout preparation

Training for every site attendance lead.

DELIVERABLE

Trained attendance leads at every site.

**What Riverbend supplies** — data access within two weeks of start, a named executive sponsor, released time for the site attendance leads, and family-contact consent under district policy.

Every phase, date and deliverable on this page is illustrative and would be fixed in a statement of work.

DELIVERY PLAN — YEAR TWO AND THE GATE

Illustrative dates and scope

# In June 2027 the board decides on year two

Year two is district-wide operation and hand-off — and it is **conditional**.

YEAR ONE — 2026-27

YEAR TWO — 2027-28




## The gate: June 2027

The board reviews pilot results against the baseline and decides to continue, adjust, or stop.

Lantern's year-two fee is not committed until that vote.

No ongoing retainer is proposed after hand-off.

### Phase 5 — District-wide operation

Sep-Dec 2027 · all three tiers live, monthly case review

### Phase 6 — Tier 3 depth

Jan-Apr 2028 · partner agreements, home-visit protocol

### Phase 7 — Hand-off

May-Jun 2028 · Riverbend runs it, Lantern reviews and leaves

Every date, phase and hand-off term on this page is illustrative and would be fixed in a statement of work.

Deliverable on hand-off: a signed operating manual and a trained district attendance team.

SCOPE AND BOUNDARY

Illustrative dates and scope

# The boundary of what we are proposing

Nine deliverables, each **included**, optional at extra cost, or out of scope.

| Deliverable | Year one | Year two |
|---|---|---|
| Attendance data audit | Included | Included |
| Root-cause barrier survey | Included | Not included |
| Early-warning threshold design | Included | Included |
| Teacher dashboard specification | Included | Included |
| Family contact playbook | Included | Included |
| Site attendance lead training | Included | Included |
| Home-visit protocol | Optional | Included |
| Community partner agreements | Optional | Included |
| Student information system integration build | Not included | Not included |

Included  Optional at additional cost  Not included

WHAT ONLY RIVERBEND CAN SUPPLY

- Data access within two weeks
- A named executive sponsor
- Released time for site leads
- Family-contact consent policy

Not included: the student information system integration build is a district IT procurement.

Scope shown is illustrative.

COMMERCIAL TERMS

All amounts are illustrative

# $312,000 over two years, year two conditional

Fixed fee by phase, payable on **deliverable acceptance**.

| Line item | Amount (USD) |
|---|---|
| **Year one — 2026-27** | |
| Phase 1 · Baseline and root cause | $42,000 |
| Phase 2 · Design and build | $68,000 |
| Phase 3 · Pilot at three schools | $54,000 |
| Phase 4 · Rollout preparation | $38,000 |
| **Year one subtotal** | **$202,000** |
| **Year two — 2027-28, conditional on the gate** | |
| Phase 5 · District-wide operation | $52,000 |
| Phase 6 · Tier 3 depth | $34,000 |
| Phase 7 · Hand-off | $24,000 |
| **Year two subtotal** | **$110,000** |
| **Total, two school years** | **$312,000** |

**$312,000**

total across two school years

PRICE BASIS AND TERMS

Fixed fee per phase, inclusive of travel and exclusive of software licences.

Payable on written acceptance of each phase deliverable.

Quotation valid for 90 days.

Every amount, subtotal, total and payment term on this page is illustrative and would be fixed in a signed statement of work.

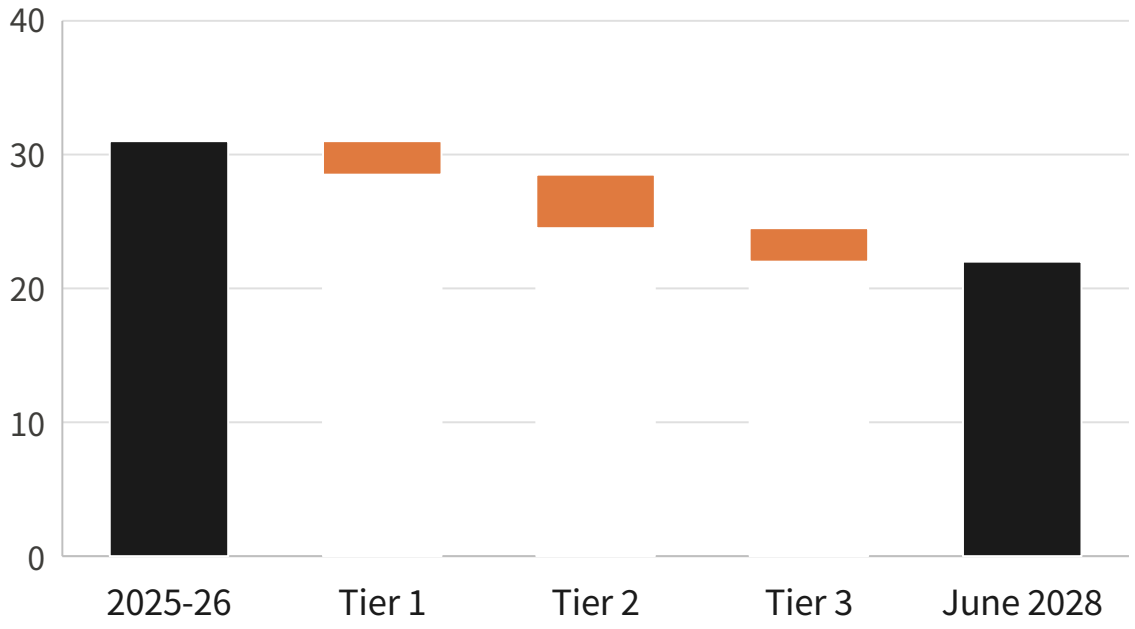
The year-two subtotal of $110,000 is released only by the June 2027 board vote; no ongoing retainer is proposed.

PROJECTED EFFECT

Modeled, not measured

# A modeled nine-point reduction

The projection is a **model, not a measurement** — and it fails first at staffing.




Modeled and illustrative, not measured. These values are not derived from the NYC benchmark series shown earlier.

## ASSUMPTIONS THIS MODEL RESTS ON

- Attendance data access from month one
- One trained attendance lead at every site
- Family contact in the same week of a Tier 2 trigger
- No change to the school calendar or bell schedule

## WHERE IT FAILS FIRST

- Site staff time is not released — the gate holds rollout until leads are named · executive sponsor
- Data access slips past month one — the baseline narrows to the four largest sites · data lead
- Tier 3 partner capacity is short — agreements move to Phase 2, Tier 3 stays at pilot sites · Lantern

THE NEXT STEP

# One vote, on 8 October 2026

Approve **Phase 1** and name the executive sponsor at the October meeting.

THE ASK

## The board approves Phase 1 funding and names the executive sponsor.

Regular meeting, 8 October 2026.
The superintendent brings the item; the board votes.

- → Within two weeks of the vote, the data access request is issued.
- → In November, the baseline report is delivered.
- → Before then, we need one named data contact from the district.



SOURCES USED IN THIS DECK

Lantern Education Partners and Riverbend Unified are fictional; the client, prices, dates and projections in this deck are illustrative.
The problem evidence is real and sourced where it appears.